

Time to buy

You finally have the deposit, your finances are in order, you are confident you have pinpointed the right home – or perhaps a few – and the gloves are coming off. Just the thought of making the commitment to buy a home is daunting enough for the first-time buyer, and the process from the start of that decision to the day you turn the key in the front door is like one big roller-coaster. But you're almost there, so strap yourself in.

Pick your target

In a market flooded with options, your motivation will help you zone in on the right home – or two, should you want a backup if you miss out in the bidding or negotiation – on your shortlist. This isn't like Tinder – it's more of a head-over-heart matter – and after following the steps to narrow down the best property for you (see Step 4), it's worth a revisit of your priorities, to ensure you're not losing your head. You will have done this blue-sky thinking when you began saving, but given how hard it is to amass a deposit, that could have been years ago, so do a refresh.

Remind yourself – why do you want this home over others?

Are you seeking financial security? Somewhere with room for a future family to grow? A step up from a share house? Do you want to make money, or are economic factors not as important to you? Reconsider each property on your shortlist through this lens.

Buyers' advocate Cate Bakos says the right time to buy is a triple axis of being able to afford the property, being able to hold it through a price downturn or correction, and the property meeting your key criteria. The worst time to buy is when you are anticipating making a fast profit. Bakos says: